JOEL'S TRAVEL COMPANION

Keep Your Health on the Road

Planes, hotels, time zones, strange food, and the one bag that keeps you safe. A plain-words guide for people who watch their blood pressure, blood sugar, and stress.

> *Three faucets, one sink. On the road, all three run harder. Stress from the airport. Sugar from the snack cart. Sodium from every meal you did not cook. This guide helps you keep each one steadier.*
>
> Joel Polley, RN

Three rules for the road

1. **Pack your plan before your clothes.** Your meds, your list, your cuff, and your pharmacist call come first. The outfits can wait.
2. **Same habits, new zip code.** Water, a walk after meals, morning light, and a real bedtime. The place changed. Your body did not.
3. **AND, not INSTEAD OF.** Nothing in here replaces your doctor's plan. Never start, stop, or move a medication on your own. Ask first.

WHAT'S INSIDE

Before you go (two weeks out). Crossing time zones. On the plane. In the hotel, with a ten-minute room workout. Strange food and eating out. Your numbers on the road. Stress and rest. When to get help. Then the pages to print: the health kit packing list, your medical card, a time-zone plan, the plane and hotel day card, the room workout card, and two wallet cards (eating out and the landing ritual). The ten numbers worth memorizing close the reading part.

TWO WEEKS OUT

Before you go

Most travel trouble is decided before the trip. Two weeks gives you time to get ready.

1 Call your pharmacist about the clock

If you cross time zones, your pill times move too. Ask your pharmacist how each one should change. Do not move them on your own. Insulin and any pill timed to meals need a written plan. Your pharmacist builds that plan for free. Ask two weeks out, not at the gate.

THE NUMBERS

Long trips across many time zones usually need a plan. Short hops rarely do. Your pharmacist decides which yours is. (Journal of Travel Medicine review, 2021; Australian Prescriber)

2 Refill, then add a week

Fill every prescription before you leave. Pack one extra week in case of delays. Keep every pill in its original labeled bottle, in your carry-on, never in checked luggage. Take a photo of each label on your phone.

3 Write your one-page medical card

Your name, your conditions, every medicine with its dose and time, your allergies, your doctor's number, your emergency contact, and your insurance. A nurse in any ER can work from that page. The printable is at the back of this guide.

4 Get a letter if you carry supplies

Syringes, pen needles, a glucose meter, a CPAP, or a blood pressure cuff all travel fine. A short letter from your doctor on letterhead answers the airport questions before they start. Ask for it at your pre-trip visit.

5 Check what your insurance does abroad

Medicare generally does not pay for care outside the United States, and it does not fly you home. Call your plan and ask two questions: are you covered where you are going, and is a medical flight home included. If the answer is no, price a travel medical policy before you book anything else.

THE NUMBERS

Medicare.gov, "Travel outside the U.S."; Johns Hopkins Medicine, "What to do if you get sick while traveling."

6 Enroll in STEP for international trips

The Smart Traveler Enrollment Program is free from the U.S. State Department. The nearest embassy knows you are there and can reach you in an emergency. It takes a few minutes at step.state.gov. It is not insurance.

7 Start moving your bedtime

Going east? Go to bed one hour earlier each night for the last two or three nights. Going west? One hour later. You land a little closer to local time.

THE NUMBERS

Shift sleep 1 hour per day for 2 to 3 days before departure. (CDC Yellow Book, Jet Lag)

THE CLOCK

Crossing time zones

Jet lag is your body clock arguing with the wall clock. Light is the loudest voice your clock hears. Meals and movement are the next two. Use all three and most people feel better within a few days.

8 East is early light. West is late light.

Flying east? Get outside in the early morning at your destination and keep evenings dim. Flying west? Wear sunglasses in the early morning and get bright light in the late afternoon and evening. This one rule is the heart of the plan.

THE NUMBERS

Your clock moves about 1 hour per day going east and about 1.5 hours per day going west. Call it roughly a day per time zone. (CDC Yellow Book, Jet Lag)

9 Eat on the new clock from the first meal

On the plane, eat when it is mealtime where you are going, not where you left. Skip the snack cart in between, unless you take insulin or a sugar-lowering pill; then follow the plan your pharmacist wrote. Your gut carries its own clock and it can follow the first breakfast you give it.

10 The 20-minute nap rule

A nap of 20 to 30 minutes sharpens you up. Anything longer steals from tonight's sleep and drags the lag out another day. Set an alarm before you lie down.

THE NUMBERS

20 to 30 minutes. (CDC Yellow Book, Jet Lag)

11 Short trip? Stay on home time

If you will be gone less than two days, do not adjust at all. Keep your home sleep and meal times as close as you can. You will be home before your clock finishes moving.

THE NUMBERS

CDC Yellow Book, Jet Lag.

12 Water is part of the clock

Being low on fluid makes every jet lag symptom worse: the headache, the fog, the cranky stomach. Drink on the plane, drink at the gate, drink when you land. If your doctor limits your fluids, use your doctor's number.

THE NUMBERS

Being low on fluid makes jet lag symptoms worse. (CDC Yellow Book, Jet Lag)

TRAVEL HACK

Coffee and melatonin are the usual jet lag advice. This plan runs without them. Light, meals, water, and a walk move your clock, and they do not raise your pressure or leave you wired at 2 AM.

IN THE AIR

On the plane

A cabin is a dry, cramped room at the height of a mountain town. Plan for the dryness, the sitting, and the salt.

13 Drink about a cup an hour

Cabin air is very dry. Bring an empty bottle through security and fill it at the gate. Sip through the flight. Say no to the alcohol cart. It dries you out, breaks up your sleep, and can make you feel worse at cabin altitude. If your doctor limits your fluids, or you have heart failure or kidney disease, use your doctor's number instead of the cup-an-hour rule.

THE NUMBERS

Cabin humidity is about 10 to 20 percent. (CDC Yellow Book, Air Travel.) A cup of water an hour is a common rule of thumb, not a CDC number.

14 Take the aisle. Move every hour or two.

Sitting still for hours lets blood pool in your calves. Pick the aisle so you can get up without asking. Walk to the back and stretch every hour or two. In your seat, pump your calves often: toes up, toes down. If you take a blood thinner, ask your doctor about flying and about falls.

THE NUMBERS

Clot risk is low on flights under 4 hours and rises on flights of 4 hours or more. A window seat raises clot risk. (CDC Yellow Book, Deep Vein Thrombosis)

ASK YOUR DOCTOR OR PHARMACIST FIRST

Compression socks help some travelers on long flights, and they are not safe for everyone, including people with some leg artery disease or nerve damage from diabetes. Ask your doctor if they are right for you. They must be fitted. Do not buy a random pair at the airport.

15 Bring your own food

One airline meal can carry about a third of the daily sodium limit, and about half of the ideal for high blood pressure. Solid food goes through security: oatmeal cups, fruit, nuts, a wrap, cut vegetables. Liquids and spreads must be 3.4 ounces or less. Medicines you need can go through in reasonable amounts; tell the officer. Check tsa.gov the week you fly.

THE NUMBERS

Airline meals run roughly 600 to 800 mg of sodium each. The daily ideal for high blood pressure is 1,500 mg; the limit is 2,300 mg. (Airline food surveys 2013 and 2019; American Heart Association)

16 Ears, nose, and the mountain in the cabin

Cabin pressure matches a mountain town. If you have a cold or a heavy stuffy head, your ears may not clear on the way down. Swallow, yawn, or sip water during descent. A saline spray keeps your nose comfortable in the dry air.

THE NUMBERS

Cabin pressure equals about 6,000 to 8,000 feet of altitude. People with heart or lung disease should have their condition stable before flying. (CDC Yellow Book, Air Travel; Aerospace Medical Association)

THE ROOM

In the hotel

A hotel room is a bedroom you did not set up. Set it up in the first ten minutes and you sleep better all week.

17 Cool, dark, quiet. In that order.

Set the thermostat cool. Pull the blackout curtain all the way and clip it shut with the pants hanger from the closet. Cover the glowing clock with a towel. Run the fan or a white noise app to drown the hallway.

THE NUMBERS

About 65 to 68 degrees F suits most adults. Sources vary, and some people over 65 sleep best a little warmer, so find your number. (Sleep Foundation; Harvard Health)

18 Ask for the quiet room

At check-in, ask for a room away from the elevator and the ice machine, on a higher floor, not facing the street. Hotels say yes more often than you think. It costs nothing to ask.

19 Make the grocery run first

Before you unpack, find a store. Buy fruit, raw nuts, oats, a bag of baby carrots, and water. Stock the mini fridge. Now you own breakfast and the late-night snack, and you do not need the room service menu.

20 The kettle is your kitchen

Every room has a kettle or a coffee maker that boils water. Oats and a sliced banana make a steady breakfast in three minutes. It beats the buffet on sodium and on price.

21 Unpack all the way

Hang your clothes. Put your cuff and your pills on the nightstand where you keep them at home. A settled room helps you feel settled. Ten minutes of order can buy a calmer week.

22 The hallway is a track

No gym? Walk the halls and take the stairs. Ten minutes after each meal is the goal, and a hotel corridor is perfect for it. Count laps, not miles.

The ten-minute room workout

ASK YOUR DOCTOR OR PHARMACIST FIRST

If you are new to exercise, have heart disease, or your doctor has given you activity limits, show this list to your doctor before your trip. If you take insulin or a sugar-lowering pill, check your sugar before you start and keep glucose tablets within reach.

No gym, no gear, no floor work. A wall, a firm chair that does not roll (desk chairs roll, so use the armchair or the wall), and the space between the bed and the TV. Wear shoes or non-slip soles. Do each move for about one minute and rest when you need to. Stop if you feel dizzy, short of breath, or any chest discomfort. If chest discomfort does not ease when you stop, call emergency services. Never hold your breath while you push or lift. The short pause in box breathing is the one exception, and you do it standing still.

1. **March in place.** Lift your knees, swing your arms. One minute to warm up.
2. **Sit-to-stand.** Sit in a firm chair with arms, stand all the way up slowly, sit back down slowly. Ten times. A strong move for legs and balance.
3. **Wall push-ups.** Hands on the wall at shoulder height, step back, lower your chest toward the wall, push away. Ten to fifteen times.

4. **Calf raises.** Hold the desk or the door frame. Rise onto your toes, lower slowly. Fifteen times. The same pump that helps your legs on the plane.
5. **Side steps.** Step to the right, bring the feet together, step to the left. One minute. Keep a hand near the desk.
6. **Standing knee lifts.** Hold a chair that does not roll, or the wall. Lift one knee toward your chest, lower, switch. Ten each side.
7. **Wall calf stretch.** Hands on the wall, one foot back, heel down, lean in gently. Hold 20 seconds each side. Keep breathing.
8. **Seated towel row.** Sit in the firm chair, loop a bath towel under both feet, hold the ends, sit tall, pull your elbows back. Ten to fifteen times.
9. **Heel-to-toe walk.** Walk the length of the room placing heel to toe, one hand on the wall. Balance work.
10. **Slow walk and box breathing.** One minute easy walk in place, then stand still for four rounds of in 4, hold 4, out 4, hold 4.

The printable card is at the back of this guide.

THE PLATE

Strange food and eating out

You did not cook it, so you do not know what is in it. Here is how to read any menu in any country for the salt, the sugar, and the trouble.

The six salt traps on every menu

- **Sauces and gravies.** Ask for them on the side and dip, do not pour.
- **Soups and broths.** Often the saltiest thing on the menu. Skip them.
- **Bread and chips before the meal.** Send the basket back before it lands.
- **Anything cured, smoked, brined, or pickled.** Salt is how they are made.
- **The word "crispy."** It means fried and salted. "Grilled," "steamed," and "roasted" are your words.
- **The cheese and the extra toppings.** Ask them to hold it. You will not miss it by the second bite.

TRAVEL HACK

Halve it before you start. Ask for a box when you order, and put half the plate in it before the first bite. Restaurant portions are two meals. You just bought tomorrow's lunch.

Cuisine cheat sheet

The plant-forward, lower-salt pick at the kinds of places you will actually find. Water or herbal tea with every one of them. Ask for no butter, ghee, cream, or cheese; many kitchens add them without saying so.

Cuisine	Order this	Skip this
Italian	Marinara over cream, pasta primavera (no parmesan), big salad with lemon or vinegar	Garlic bread, salami, prosciutto, pancetta, Alfredo, minestrone
Mexican	Soft corn tortillas, black beans (not refried), pico de gallo, fresh guacamole, fajita vegetables	The chip basket, queso, sour cream, extra cheese
Chinese	Steamed vegetables and tofu, steamed rice, vegetable dumplings (ask what is inside), sauce on the side	Fried rice, crispy anything, soup, soy sauce poured on
Indian	Dal (lentils), chana masala, vegetable curry with no ghee or cream, plain rice or roti, cucumber salad	Naan with butter, pakora, papadum, creamy korma
Middle Eastern	Hummus, tabbouleh, fattoush, grilled vegetables, baked falafel if offered	Fried falafel, pickles and olives by the handful, extra pita, feta, lentil soup
Diner	Oatmeal made with water and fruit, baked potato, side salad with lemon or vinegar, fruit cup	Bacon, sausage, hash browns, gravy, pancakes with syrup
Airport	Oatmeal cup, fruit cup, hummus and carrots, a salad with no cheese or meat and dressing on the side	The hot sandwich, the pizza slice, the chips, the pretzels, the big soda

ASK YOUR DOCTOR OR PHARMACIST FIRST

Beans, greens, and fruit are rich in potassium, the mineral that pushes back on sodium. If you have kidney disease or take a blood pressure pill that raises potassium, ask your doctor how much is right for you. If you take warfarin, keep your leafy greens steady from day to day and ask your pharmacist. Herbal teas are fine for most people; skip licorice tea, and ask your pharmacist about herbal teas if you take a blood thinner or a blood pressure pill.

Eating abroad: the four-word rule

> *Boil it, cook it, peel it, or forget it.*
>
> The traveler's rule

- **Drinks.** Sealed bottles and canned fizzy water are the safe choice. Skip ice unless you know the water is safe. Brush your teeth with bottled water.
- **Fruit.** Bananas, oranges, and anything you peel yourself are safe. Pre-cut fruit is not.
- **Hot means safe.** Food served steaming hot from a busy stall is safer than lukewarm food from a quiet buffet.

- **Boiling water.** A rolling boil for one full minute makes water safe. Three minutes if you are above 6,500 feet.

23 If your stomach turns: the home rehydration mix

Travelers' diarrhea takes water and salt out fast. Replace both. Stir 6 level teaspoons of sugar and half a level teaspoon of salt into 1 liter (about 4 cups) of clean water and sip it through the day. Store-bought packets are better if you can find them. Ask your doctor first if you have high blood pressure, heart failure, or kidney disease, because the mix carries salt. If you take a water pill, a blood pressure pill, metformin, or a diabetes pill, and you have vomiting or diarrhea, call your doctor or pharmacist the same day. Check your sugar more often while you are sick. See a doctor if it lasts more than one day, sooner if you feel weak or dizzy, or if you see blood or have a fever. Call emergency services for dizziness when you stand, confusion, no urine, or if you cannot keep fluids down.

THE NUMBERS

6 tsp sugar + 1/2 tsp salt + 1 liter clean water. (Rehydration Project, WHO-based home recipe)

YOUR NUMBERS

Blood pressure and blood sugar on the road

Your cuff and your meter are the two smallest things in your bag and the two most important. Pack them in the carry-on and use them the way you do at home.

24 Same time, same arm, same chair

Check your pressure every morning before breakfast, sitting, feet flat, after five quiet minutes. Take your pills on your doctor's schedule. One high number is a note, not an emergency, unless the top number is 180 or higher or the bottom number is 120 or higher. A pattern of high numbers is a phone call to your doctor.

25 Know your stop sign

The stop sign is a top number of 180 or higher, or a bottom number of 120 or higher. Either one counts. No symptoms? Sit quietly and check again in five minutes. Still there? Call your doctor right away. If you cannot reach them, go to urgent care or the ER. Any symptom with that number (headache, chest pain, back pain, trouble breathing, vision change, confusion, trouble speaking, a drooping face, numbness, or a weak arm or leg)? Call emergency services now. Do not drive yourself.

THE NUMBERS

A top number over 180 or a bottom number over 120 is what the American Heart Association calls a hypertensive crisis, an emergency level. (American Heart Association; Mayo Clinic)

26 Carry sugar on your body, not in the bag

If you take insulin or a pill that can drop your sugar, glucose tablets live in your pocket, not the overhead bin. A low reading gets 15 grams of fast sugar, then a recheck in 15 minutes. Repeat until you are 70 or higher, then eat a snack or a meal. If you are confused, cannot swallow, or do not come up after two rounds, call emergency services. Follow your doctor's plan if it is different.

THE NUMBERS

Below 70 mg/dL is low. The 15-15 rule: 15 grams of carbohydrate, recheck in 15 minutes. (American Diabetes Association)

27 Insulin hates a hot car and a cold hold

Checked bags can get very cold in the hold. Rental cars bake in the lot. Insulin and many pens go in the carry-on in a small cooler pouch, never against ice. Follow the storage steps on your label, and ask your pharmacist about your insulin before you pack.

THE FIRST FAUCET

Stress and rest on the road

Travel is a stress test with a boarding pass. Fight-or-flight is your body's emergency backup system. It is not designed to stay on. These five habits can help calm your body every day you are away.

1. **Walk after every meal.** Ten minutes is enough. The hotel hall, the block around the restaurant, the terminal. It can help steady blood sugar, and it helps steady you.
2. **Morning light within 30 minutes of waking.** Step outside, even for ten minutes. It sets your clock and your mood for the day.

3. **Box breathing at the gate.** In for 4, hold 4, out for 4, hold 4. Four rounds, sitting still. Nobody around you will know. Never while driving. Stop if you feel dizzy.
4. **Take the stairs.** Airports, hotels, and train stations are full of them. Each flight is a free dose of movement.
5. **Keep one rest day.** Even on vacation, set one day aside with no itinerary. God built rest into the week on purpose. A Sabbath on the road is still a Sabbath.

TRAVEL HACK

Pack a "landing ritual" and run it every arrival: water, a ten-minute walk outside, unpack, cuff on the nightstand, shower, lights low. Five steps, twenty minutes. Your body learns that the ritual means home. The landing-ritual wallet card is on the eating-out page at the back.

BE READY

When to get help

Twenty years in the ER and the ICU taught me one thing about emergencies: the people who do well are the ones who decided what to do before it happened. Decide now.

Call emergency services right now if you have

- **Chest pain or pressure** that lasts more than a few minutes, or comes with sweating, nausea, or pain in the arm, jaw, or back.
- **Stroke signs. Think FAST:** Face drooping, Arm weak, Speech slurred, Time to call. Note the time it started.
- **A top number of 180 or higher, or a bottom number of 120 or higher,** with any symptom: headache, chest pain, back pain, trouble breathing, vision change, confusion, trouble speaking, a drooping face, numbness, or a weak arm or leg.
- **A blood sugar under 70** that will not come up after two rounds of the 15-15 rule, or any confusion, trouble swallowing, or passing out.
- **Severe shortness of breath** or a swollen, painful calf after a long flight (a clot can travel to the lung).

The numbers to dial

Where	Dial	Note
United States and Canada	911	Works from any phone, locked or not
European Union and most of Europe	112	Also works as a fallback on most cell phones worldwide
United Kingdom	999	112 also works
Australia	000	From a foreign phone, 112 connects
Anywhere else	Check before you land	112 does not work in every country. Write the local number on your medical card the day you arrive

How to find care abroad

- **Your insurance card has a 24-hour line.** Call it first. They know the hospitals that bill them.
- **The hotel front desk** knows the nearest hospital and can call a taxi or ambulance in the local language.
- **The U.S. embassy or consulate** keeps a list of English-speaking doctors. STEP enrollment makes them easier to reach.
- **Hand them your card.** The one-page medical card at the back of this guide. Every ER can read a med list.

Numbers worth memorizing

Number	What it is
Up to 1 day per zone	How long your clock takes to catch up. A bit less going west
20 to 30 minutes	The longest nap that will not steal from tonight
A cup an hour	Water in the air, a rule of thumb. A fluid limit from your doctor wins
4 hours	Where clot risk starts to rise. Aisle seat, move, calf pumps
65 to 68 F	A cool sleeping room for most adults
1,500 / 2,300 mg	Sodium a day: the ideal with high blood pressure, and the limit
180 top or 120 bottom	The stop sign, either number. Recheck in 5 minutes; still there, call your doctor. Any symptom, call emergency services
Under 70	Low blood sugar. 15 grams of sugar, recheck in 15 minutes. Two rounds and still low, call
6 tsp + 1/2 tsp + 1 L	Sugar, salt, clean water: the rehydration mix. Ask first with heart or kidney disease
112	The emergency number across Europe and on most cell phones. Not every country

PRINT THIS PAGE

The health kit packing list

Everything on this page rides in your carry-on, never in a checked bag. Check each box as it goes in.

Medicines and devices

- [ ] Every prescription, original bottles
- [ ] One extra week of each
- [ ] Photo of every label on phone
- [ ] Blood pressure cuff + batteries
- [ ] Glucose meter, strips, lancets
- [ ] Glucose tablets (in pocket)
- [ ] Insulin + cooler pouch (no ice)
- [ ] Pen needles or syringes
- [ ] Doctor's letter for supplies
- [ ] Pharmacist's time-zone plan
- [ ] Saline nasal spray
- [ ] Compression socks (if advised)
- [ ] Oral rehydration packets
- [ ] Bandages, antibiotic ointment
- [ ] Thermometer
- [ ] Any allergy or rescue medicine

Papers and cards

- [ ] One-page medical card (next page)
- [ ] Insurance card + 24-hour line
- [ ] Travel medical or evacuation policy
- [ ] Passport copy (paper and phone)
- [ ] STEP enrollment confirmation
- [ ] Doctor and pharmacy phone numbers
- [ ] Emergency contact, two people
- [ ] Local emergency number, written in

Food and water

- [ ] Empty water bottle (fill past security)
- [ ] Oatmeal cups
- [ ] Raw nuts, portioned
- [ ] Fresh fruit for the flight
- [ ] Hummus (3.4 oz or less) + carrots
- [ ] Herbal tea bags (no caffeine, no licorice)
- [ ] Sliced banana for the oats
- [ ] Reusable spoon

Sleep and movement

- [ ] Sleep mask
- [ ] Ear plugs
- [ ] Pants hanger (curtain clip)
- [ ] Walking shoes you can live in
- [ ] Light jacket for the cold cabin
- [ ] Phone alarm set for the 20-minute nap
- [ ] A real book, not a screen
- [ ] This guide

PRINT THIS PAGE. FOLD IT. KEEP IT IN YOUR WALLET.

My medical card

Fill it in with a pen. Give a copy to your travel partner. Hand it to any nurse or doctor who asks what you take.

FULL NAME _____

DATE OF BIRTH _____

BLOOD TYPE (IF KNOWN) _____

CONDITIONS I LIVE WITH _____

ALLERGIES _____

My medicines, dose, and time

Medicine	Dose	When I take it	What it is for

MY DOCTOR AND PHONE _____

MY PHARMACY AND PHONE _____

EMERGENCY CONTACT 1 _____

EMERGENCY CONTACT 2 _____

INSURANCE + 24-HR LINE _____

LOCAL EMERGENCY NUMBER _____

PRINT THIS PAGE

My time-zone plan

One page, filled in before you fly. Bring it to your pharmacist and let them write the medicine lines.

TRIP DATES _____

HOME TIME ZONE _____

DESTINATION TIME ZONE _____

HOURS OF DIFFERENCE _____

DIRECTION (EAST OR WEST) _____

My light plan

THE RULE

East: early morning light, dim evenings. West: sunglasses in the early morning, bright light late afternoon and evening. Up to a day per time zone to adjust, a bit less going west.

MORNING LIGHT PLAN _____

EVENING: DIM OR BRIGHT _____

My medicine plan (pharmacist fills this in)

Medicine	Home time	Travel time	Notes

BEDTIME SHIFT STARTS _____

FIRST NEW-CLOCK MEAL _____

PRINT THIS PAGE

The plane and hotel day card

Tick the boxes on travel day and on every day away. Habits travel better with a checklist.

Travel day

- [ ] Pills and cuff in the carry-on
- [ ] Glucose tablets in pocket
- [ ] Empty bottle, filled past security
- [ ] Own food packed, bread basket declined
- [ ] Aisle seat
- [ ] Walk or stretch every 1 to 2 hours
- [ ] Calf pumps every 20 to 30 minutes
- [ ] Water every hour, no alcohol
- [ ] Eat on the destination clock
- [ ] Sunglasses or light per the plan
- [ ] Box breathing at the gate
- [ ] Landing ritual run on arrival

Every day away

- [ ] Cuff before breakfast, same arm
- [ ] Pills on the pharmacist's plan
- [ ] Morning light within 30 minutes
- [ ] Water, your doctor's amount
- [ ] Walk 10 minutes after each meal
- [ ] Sauce on the side, portion halved
- [ ] Stairs over elevators
- [ ] Room cool, dark, and quiet
- [ ] Ten-minute room workout
- [ ] Nap 20 to 30 minutes max, if any
- [ ] One rest day this week
- [ ] Grateful for one thing today

WATER

Most people do well on about half their body weight in ounces a day, and a little more on flying days. If your doctor limits your fluids, or you have heart failure or kidney disease, use your doctor's number instead.

PRINT THIS PAGE. TAPE IT TO THE HOTEL MIRROR.

The ten-minute room workout

About one minute each. Shoes on. Use a chair that does not roll. Hold the chair or the wall whenever you want. Never hold your breath while you push or lift. Stop if you feel dizzy, short of breath, or have any chest discomfort. If chest discomfort does not ease when you stop, call emergency services. Ask your doctor before you start if you have heart disease or activity limits.

#	Move	How many	Tip
1	March in place	1 minute	Knees up, arms swinging
2	Sit-to-stand	10	Firm chair that does not roll, slow both ways
3	Wall push-ups	10 to 15	Hands at shoulder height
4	Calf raises	15	Hold the desk, lower slowly
5	Side steps	1 minute	Hand near the desk
6	Standing knee lifts	10 each side	Hold the firm chair or the wall
7	Wall calf stretch	20 seconds each side	Heel down, keep breathing
8	Seated towel row	10 to 15	Towel under your feet, sit tall
9	Heel-to-toe walk	Across the room	One hand on the wall
10	Easy walk + box breathing	1 minute + 4 rounds	In 4, hold 4, out 4, hold 4, standing still

Seven-day check-off

Day 1 ☐ Day 2 ☐ Day 3 ☐ Day 4 ☐ Day 5 ☐ Day 6 ☐ Day 7 ☐

WHY TEN MINUTES MATTERS

Your muscles are the biggest sugar sink you own, and a working calf is the pump that keeps blood moving out of your legs. Ten minutes a day on the road helps keep both switched on. Add a walk after each meal and you have the whole plan.

PRINT THIS PAGE. CUT ON THE LINE. KEEP IT IN YOUR WALLET.

The eating-out pocket card

Nine lines to read any menu, and the five-step landing ritual. Cut on the lines and keep both in your wallet.

JOEL'S EATING-OUT CARD

1. **Sauce on the side.** Dip, do not pour.
2. **Send the bread basket back.** Before it lands.
3. **Halve it before the first bite.** Box the rest.
4. **"Crispy" means fried and salted.** Grilled, steamed, roasted are your words.
5. **Skip soup, cured, smoked, pickled.** Salt is how they are made.
6. **Beans, lentils, vegetables first.** Fill half the plate with plants.
7. **Water or herbal tea.** No alcohol, no soda, no coffee.
8. **Abroad: boil it, cook it, peel it, or forget it.** Sealed drinks, no ice.
9. **Walk ten minutes after.** Every meal, every day.

Joel Polley, RN · BraveWorks RN · bpquiz.com

JOEL'S LANDING RITUAL · RUN IT EVERY ARRIVAL

1. **Water.** A full glass before anything else.
2. **Ten minutes outside.** Walk in daylight. It tells your clock where you are.
3. **Unpack all the way.** Cuff and pills on the nightstand, where they live at home.
4. **Shower, lights low.** Thermostat cool, curtain clipped, clock covered.
5. **Four rounds of box breathing.** In 4, hold 4, out 4, hold 4. Then bed on the new clock.

Five steps, twenty minutes. · Joel Polley, RN

This is education and lifestyle support, not medical advice, diagnosis, or treatment. Joel Polley is a Registered Nurse, not a prescribing physician. We never change your medications. Never start, stop, or adjust a medication or its timing without your doctor or pharmacist. Ask your doctor before starting any new exercise. Figures come from the CDC Yellow Book (jet lag, air travel, deep vein thrombosis), the American Heart Association, the American Diabetes Association, Mayo Clinic, Johns Hopkins Medicine, Medicare.gov, the Sleep Foundation, the Rehydration Project, the Aerospace Medical Association, a 2021 Journal of Travel Medicine review, Australian Prescriber, and airline food surveys from 2013 and 2019, as of November 2026. Airport security rules change; check tsa.gov before you fly. In an emergency, call your local emergency number.

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